PYTHON FOR DATA SCIENCE · LESSON 4 OF 29

Control Flow: if, elif, else, Nested Conditions & match

Make programs decide. Learn indentation, if/elif/else, comparison and logical conditions, truthiness, conditional expressions (ternary), nested decisions, the match statement, and how Python's if maps to Excel's IF/IFS and SQL's CASE WHEN, with data-flavoured examples.

Python class 3 | Python 3.13 | Beginner | 90 min

By the end of this lesson you can

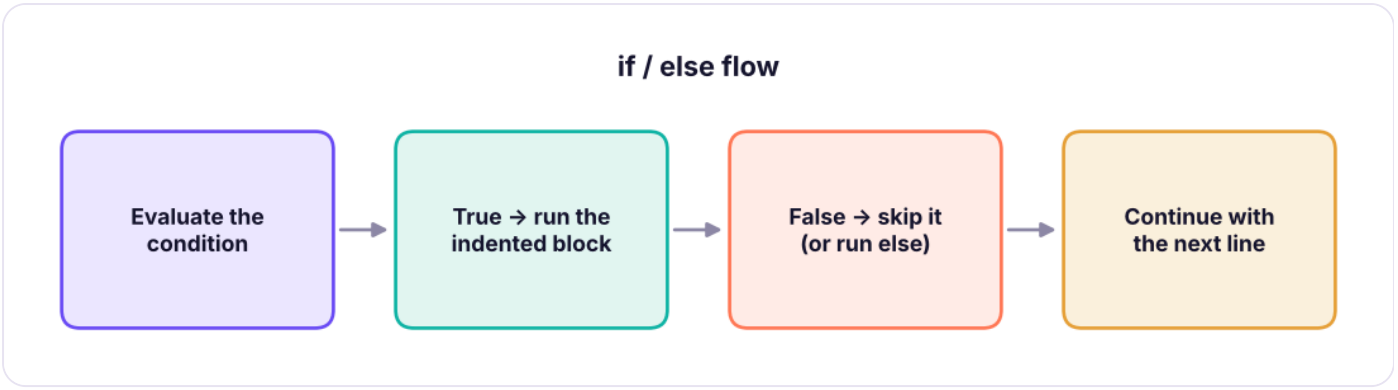
- Write correct if / elif / else blocks and explain why indentation matters
- Combine conditions with and, or, not, in, chained comparisons and truthiness
- Use conditional expressions and the match statement
- Order conditions correctly and avoid common branching bugs
- Translate a spreadsheet or SQL rule into Python

Datasets used

`employees_small.csv`

Decisions and indentation

A program normally runs line by line. **Control flow** lets it choose between paths. In Python, a **colon** `:` starts a block and **indentation** (4 spaces by convention) says which lines belong to it.



An if statement tests a condition. If it is True the indented block runs; otherwise Python moves on (or runs else).

Python

```
marks = 82
if marks ⩾ 40:
    print("Pass")
    print("Well done!")
print("This line always runs")
```

OUTPUT

```
Pass
Well done!
This line always runs
```

Python

```
if True:
print("not indented")        # IndentationError: expected an indented block after 'if'
statement
```

COMMON MISTAKES

Indentation rules

Use **4 spaces** (never mix tabs and spaces). Everything in the same block has the **same indentation**. A missing colon or wrong indentation causes `SyntaxError` / `IndentationError`.

if / elif / else

Python

```
marks = 82
if marks ⩾ 90:
    grade = "A+"
elif marks ⩾ 75:
    grade = "A"
elif marks ⩾ 60:
    grade = "B"
elif marks ⩾ 40:
    grade = "C"
else:
    grade = "Fail"
print(marks, "→", grade)
```

OUTPUT

```
82 → A
```

Python checks the conditions **top to bottom** and runs the **first** one that is true, then skips the rest. This is Excel's nested `IF` / `IFS` and SQL's `CASE WHEN` (Excel Lesson 5, SQL Lesson 7).

COMMON MISTAKES **Order matters**

If you test `marks ⩾ 40` first, an 82 gets "C" because the first true branch wins. Put the most specific / strictest condition first.

Python

```
for m in (95, 82, 61, 45, 12):
    g = "A+" if m ⩾ 90 else "A" if m ⩾ 75 else "B" if m ⩾ 60 else "C" if m ⩾ 40 else
"Fail"    # chained conditional expression
    print(m, g)
```

OUTPUT

```
95 A+
82 A
61 B
45 C
12 Fail
```

Conditional expression (ternary)

`value_if_true if condition else value_if_false` is Python's one-line `IF()`:

```python
salary = 97000
band = "High" if salary ⩾ 100000 else "Standard"
bonus = salary * 0.1 if band == "High" else 0
print(band, bonus)
```

OUTPUT

```
Standard 0
```

Conditions

Comparison and logical operators

```python
age, city, income = 29, "Pune", 85000
print(age ⩾ 18 and city == "Pune")                    # both must be true
print(city in ("Pune", "Mumbai") or income > 100000)   # at least one
print(not (age < 18))
print(18 ⩽ age < 60)                                    # chained comparison
if 18 ⩽ age < 60 and income ⩾ 50000 and city in ("Pune", "Mumbai", "Delhi"):
    print("Eligible for the metro premium plan")
```

OUTPUT

```
True
True
True
True
Eligible for the metro premium plan
```

Truthiness

Python treats "empty" and zero-like values as False (Lesson 2), so you can test them directly:

Python

```
name = ""
items = [3, 5]
note = None
if not name: print("name is empty")
if items: print("items has", len(items), "elements")
if note is None: print("note is missing")                    # use `is None`, not `== None`
if 0 < len(items) ⩽ 5: print("small list")
```

OUTPUT

```
name is empty
items has 2 elements
note is missing
small list
```

Membership and string tests

Python

```
status = "Shipped"
if status in ("Shipped", "Delivered"): print("order has left the warehouse")
email = "kavya.iyer@abc.in"
if "@" in email and email.endswith(".in"): print("Indian email address")
```

OUTPUT

```
order has left the warehouse
Indian email address
```

Nested conditions

Python

```
is_member, cart_value = True, 3200
if cart_value > 0:
    if is_member:
        discount = 0.1 if cart_value ⩾ 3000 else 0.05
    else:
        discount = 0.02 if cart_value ⩾ 3000 else 0
    print(f"Discount: {discount:.0%}")
else:
    print("Cart is empty")
```

OUTPUT

```
Discount: 10%
```

Prefer **flat** conditions with `and` to deeply nested ones when they read clearly:

Python

```python
def shipping_fee(value, is_member):
    if value ⩽ 0: return 0
    if is_member and value ⩾ 500: return 0
    if value ⩾ 1500: return 0
    return 49
print([shipping_fee(v, m) for v, m in [(0, True), (600, True), (600, False), (1600,
False)]])
```

OUTPUT

```
[0, 0, 49, 0]
```

Returning early (**guard clauses**) keeps code flat and readable.

match: structural pattern matching (3.10+)

`match` compares one value with several patterns: a clean alternative to a long chain of `==` tests.

Python

```python
def describe_status(code):
    match code:
        case 200 | 201:
            return "success"
        case 301 | 302:
            return "redirect"
        case 404:
            return "not found"
        case int(c) if 500 ⩽ c < 600:
            return "server error"
        case _:
            return "unknown"
print([describe_status(c) for c in (200, 404, 503, 999)])
```

OUTPUT

```
['success', 'not found', 'server error', 'unknown']
```

Python

```
def handle(command):
    match command.split():
        case ["load", filename]:  return f"loading {filename}"
        case ["save", filename]:  return f"saving {filename}"
        case ["quit"]:            return "bye"
        case _:                   return "unknown command"
print(handle("load sales.csv"), "|", handle("quit"), "|", handle("fly away"))
```

OUTPUT

```
loading sales.csv | bye | unknown command
```

Data examples

Rule-based bonus (the same as an Excel IF + AND)

Python

```
import pandas as pd
emp = pd.read_csv("employees_small.csv")
def bonus(salary, rating, dept):
    if rating ⩾ 5: rate = 0.15
    elif rating ⩾ 4: rate = 0.10
    elif rating ⩾ 3: rate = 0.05
    else: rate = 0
    if dept == "Sales": rate += 0.02            # extra for Sales
    return round(salary * rate)
emp["bonus"] = [bonus(s, r, d) for s, r, d in zip(emp.salary, emp.rating, emp.department)]
emp[["name", "department", "salary", "rating", "bonus"]].head(8)
```

OUTPUT

	name	department	salary	rating	bonus
0	Kavya Iyer	HR	97000	4	9700
1	Imran Reddy	Finance	157000	3	7850
2	Harpreet Kulkarni	Finance	131000	4	13100
3	Diya Iyer	HR	90000	4	9000
4	Simran Iyer	HR	139000	4	13900
5	Saanvi Rao	HR	83000	4	8300
6	Isha Mehta	Sales	57000	3	3990
7	Aarav Kulkarni	HR	101000	2	0

8 rows × 5 columns

(In pandas you would use `np.where`, `np.select` or `.apply`: Lesson 19. Writing the rule once as a function makes it testable.)

A small decision tree: loan pre-check

Python

```python
def loan_precheck(age, income, existing_emi, credit_score):
    reasons = []
    if age < 21 or age > 60: reasons.append("age outside 21-60")
    if income < 25000: reasons.append("income below ₹25,000")
    if existing_emi > 0.5 * income: reasons.append("EMIs exceed 50% of income")
    if credit_score < 650: reasons.append("credit score below 650")
    return ("Eligible", []) if not reasons else ("Review", reasons)
print(loan_precheck(34, 70000, 20000, 730))
print(loan_precheck(19, 22000, 15000, 610))
```

OUTPUT

```
('Eligible', [])
('Review', ['age outside 21-60', 'income below ₹25,000', 'EMIs exceed 50% of income',
'credit score below 650'])
```

Collecting **all** failing reasons is more useful than stopping at the first, and shows how a series of independent `if` statements (not `elif`) is sometimes right.

`if`/`elif` vs several `if`s

Pattern	Use when
`if … elif … else`	Choices are **mutually exclusive**: only one branch should run
Several separate `if`	Each condition is **independent**: more than one may apply (collecting reasons, applying several rules)

Common mistakes

Mistake	Fix
`if x = 5:` (assignment)	`if x == 5:`
`if x == 3 or 4:` (always true: 4 is truthy)	`if x in (3, 4):`
`if x == None:`	`if x is None:`
Comparing floats with `==`	`math.isclose`
Forgetting `elif` ordering	strictest first
`if len(items) > 0:` (verbose)	`if items:`
Deep nesting	guard clauses / `and` / helper functions

DO IT WITH AI

Do it with AI

Take an Excel rule from your own work, such as a nested IF for commission, and ask an assistant to convert it to Python with test cases. Then write five edge-case tests yourself (boundaries like exactly 50,000, blanks, negative values) and see if the code survives.

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A colon starts a block; **indentation** (4 spaces) defines it. `if / elif / else` runs the first true branch.
- Combine conditions with `and`, `or`, `not`, `in`, chained comparisons; empty/zero/None are falsy; test `None` with `is None`.
- Use the **ternary** `a if cond else b` for simple choices and the `match` statement for many exact cases and patterns.
- Order conditions from strictest to loosest; prefer flat code with guard clauses; use separate `if`s when several rules can apply.
- Wrap rules in functions so they can be tested and reused.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What does `x if cond else y` do?

A Runs a loop

B Evaluates to x when cond is True, otherwise y

C Defines a function

D Compares x and y

Answer: B. It is Python's conditional (ternary) expression.

2. Which condition is correct for "x is 3 or 4"?

A `x == 3 or 4`

B `x in (3, 4)`

C `x = 3 or 4`

D `x is (3, 4)`

Answer: B. `x == 3 or 4` is always truthy because 4 is truthy.

3. With `marks = 82`, which grade does `if marks ⩾ 40: "C" elif marks ⩾ 75: "A"` give?

A C

B A

C Fail

D Nothing

Answer: A. The first true branch wins, so the order is wrong.

4. Which is the best way to test for None?

A `x == None`

B `x is None`

C `not x`

D `x = None`

Answer: B. `is None` tests identity and avoids surprises with falsy values like 0.

5. What is a guard clause?

A A loop that never ends

B An early return that handles a special case so the rest of the function is not nested

C A try/except block

D A decorator

Answer: B. Guard clauses keep code flat and readable.

6. What does `match` do?

- **A** Matches regular expressions only
- **B** Compares a value against patterns and runs the first matching case
- **C** Loops over a list
- **D** Imports modules

Answer: B. Structural pattern matching arrived in Python 3.10.

EXERCISE **Rules in code**

Write `delivery_charge(order_value, city, express)`: free if order ≥ ₹1,500; otherwise ₹49 in metros (Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Chennai, Kolkata, Hyderabad) and ₹79 elsewhere; express adds ₹100 unless the value is ≥ ₹5,000. Test five cases including boundaries.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```
METROS = {"Delhi", "Mumbai", "Bengaluru", "Chennai", "Kolkata", "Hyderabad"}
def delivery_charge(value, city, express=False):
    fee = 0 if value ⩾ 1500 else (49 if city in METROS else 79)
    if express and value < 5000: fee += 100
    return fee
tests = [(1500, "Pune", False), (1499, "Delhi", False), (1499, "Pune", True), (5000,
"Pune", True), (100, "Mumbai", True)]
print([delivery_charge(*t) for t in tests])      # [0, 49, 179, 0, 149]
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: What is the difference between `elif` and multiple `if` statements? `elif` branches are mutually exclusive (only the first true runs); separate `if`s are all evaluated, so several can run.

Q: How do you write a switch-case in Python? Use `match`/`case` (3.10+), or a dictionary mapping values to functions or results.

Q: What are falsy values in Python? `False`, `None`, `0`, `0.0`, `""`, `[]`, `{}`, `()`, `set()`, and objects whose `__bool__` returns False or `__len__` returns 0.

Q: How do you replace nested if/else cleanly? Guard clauses, combined conditions, lookup tables (dicts), or polymorphism.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.